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In New Review

The Observer

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Sunday 23 March 2025
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All families 'to be worse off by 2030' as poor bear the brunt

- Blow for PM over living standards pledge
- Chancellor under pressure ahead of cuts

Toby Helm
Political Editor

Living standards for all UK families are set to fall by 2030, with those on the lowest incomes declining twice as fast as middle and high earners, according to new data that raises serious questions about Keir Starmer's pledge to make working people better off.

The grim economic analysis,

Spring statement
Reeves has choices other than loading the cost of lacklustre growth on the most vulnerable
Observer Comment, p42

produced by the respected Joseph Rowntree Foundation (JRF), comes before the chancellor, Rachel Reeves, makes her spring statement on Wednesday in which she will announce new cuts to public spending rather than increase borrowing or raise taxes, so as to keep within the government's "iron clad" fiscal rules.

In December, the prime minister announced a series of new "milestones" that he said would be passed before the next general election, which is likely to be held in 2029. The first of these was "putting more money in the pockets of working people".

But with many Labour MPs already deeply concerned over Reeves's plan to raise about £3bn by cutting benefits, including for disabled people, evidence that living standards are on course to fall markedly under a Labour government – and to decline most for the least well off – will add to the mood of growing disquiet in the party's ranks.

The JRF analysis rests on a realistic assumption that the Office for Budget Responsibility (OBR) will adjust its

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Flying the flag



Amber Anning celebrates taking the 400m gold at the World Athletics Indoor Championships in Nanjing, China, yesterday. She crossed the line in 50.6sec to pip American Alexis Holmes by 300ths of a second (Sport, page 18). Lintao Zhang/Getty

We've forgotten lessons of Covid, say experts

Robin McKie
Science Editor

Key scientific lessons learned during the Covid-19 pandemic are being forgotten, UK scientists have warned.

The researchers have raised the alarm as the nation marks the fifth anniversary of the introduction of lockdown, which was announced by then prime minister Boris Johnson on 23 March 2020.

The decision was made to prevent

NHS hospitals being swamped by hundreds of thousands of new cases of seriously ill Covid patients.

However, there is no evidence that the health service would be any better prepared today should another lethal virus appear in the near future, scientists said.

"Every winter, even before Covid, hospitals were run very close to the edge," said Prof Rowland Kao of Edinburgh University. "When the disease arrived, the NHS was simply not

in a position to take any more. And there are no signs it will be different next time. Indeed, it is likely to be worse."

Nor is there any evidence that the country has understood the psychological consequences triggered by placing the nation into lockdown.

It might have been moderately effective for reducing infection but it underestimated the need for

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The Observer Magazine

In the magazine

Gnawing anxiety, and how to beat it

A vicious cycle of fear and dread is besetting more and more of us. One therapist has found a solution

The man who put the joy in sex
Tale of the 70s bedroom guru, his wife ... and his lover

In this section

Try and try again
England beat France in last-minute thriller

In Sport



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The Observer

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Labour to 'fix benefit system to get people back into work'

- Radical overhaul to cut cost of welfare
- Plan aims to end all-or-nothing choice

Michael Savage
Policy Editor

Britain's broken welfare system is fuelling the "greatest unemployment challenge of a generation", ministers have concluded as they draw up a root-and-branch overhaul designed to counter the spiralling numbers deemed too unwell to work.

Rules that force benefit claimants into an "all or nothing" choice

between working and being deemed too sick to work are set to be redrawn, the *Observer* understands. It follows new evidence that thousands of people who want to work are worried about taking steps to return to the workplace out of fear that their benefits will be withdrawn.

"The Tories promised to get people off benefits and into work," said a government source. "But instead they created a system that wrote people off and left them without support."

"This Labour government will fix the broken benefits system because getting more people into good jobs is crucial to improving their living standards and life chances, and getting the welfare bill on a more sustainable footing."

Under the current system, those deemed too sick to work receive a higher payment than those deemed either able to work or able to do some work. Those unable to work at all receive an extra £416 a month.

Meanwhile, the higher level of support has continued to increase during a long period in which basic benefits were frozen. Ministers believe that

Bearing witness



A Palestinian girl stands among Hamas fighters at yesterday's handover of three Israeli hostages in Gaza. (Concern over condition of released Israelis, page 2; The Palestinian families rowing not to leave Gaza, pages 26-27; Eyad Baba/AFP)

Gambling firms send users' data to Facebook

Shanti Das
& Jon Ungood-Thomas

Gambling companies are covertly tracking visitors to their websites and sending their data to Facebook's parent without consent in an apparent breach of data protection laws.

The information is then being used by Facebook's owner, Meta, to profile people as gamblers and flood them with ads for casinos and betting sites, the *Observer* can reveal. A hid-

den tracking tool embedded in dozens of UK gambling websites has been extracting visitors' data – including details of the webpages they view and the buttons they click – and sharing it with the social media company.

By law, data should only be used and shared for marketing purposes, with explicit permission obtained from users on the websites in which the tools are embedded. But testing by the *Observer* of 150 gambling sites – including virtual casinos, sports bet-

ting sites and online bingo – found widespread breaches of the rules.

This weekend, Iain Duncan Smith, the Conservative chair of the all-party parliamentary group on gambling reform, called for an "immediate intervention". He said: "The use of tools such as Meta Pixel without explicit consent seems wholly in breach of the law and should be immediately stopped. The gambling

Starmer's eco insults
Tories must find validation in the PM's promise to fulfil their dreams of humbling environmentalists

Catherine Bennett, p45

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Experts' fashion tips



Step into spring with advice from
Trinny Woodall
Kenya Hunt
Alexa Chung
Lucinda Chambers
Pat McGrath

In the magazine



Meet the new Coen duo

Ethan Coen and Tricia Cooke on their riotous lesbian road movie

In New Review



What's up with gen Z?
Why there's a real problem with mental health

This section



The Observer

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Tax cuts will backfire, top economists warn Hunt

- Ex-Treasury aides say fiscal rules must go
- Chancellor 'courting danger on UK debt'

Phillip Inman
& Toby Helm

Leading economists warn today that Jeremy Hunt will "cost the country dear" if he gambles on pre-election cuts to tax and spending in this week's budget.

Two former advisers to the Treasury said that instead of decisions aimed at "sabotaging prospects for the next government", the chancellor should focus on the long-term national interest with measures to spur investment and growth.

In a statement to the *Observer*, Dimitri Zenghelis, a former head of economic forecasting at the Treasury, and Anna Valero, a former member of the chancellor's economic advisory council, said the country needed to break out of a cycle of short-termism.

"Tax cuts to stimulate a pre-election consumer spending spree

is the last thing the British economy needs and will cost us all dear," they said.

"For over a decade, economic short-termism and low and volatile investment has saddled the country with macroeconomic instability, stagnant living standards and one of the poorest productivity performances among major economies."

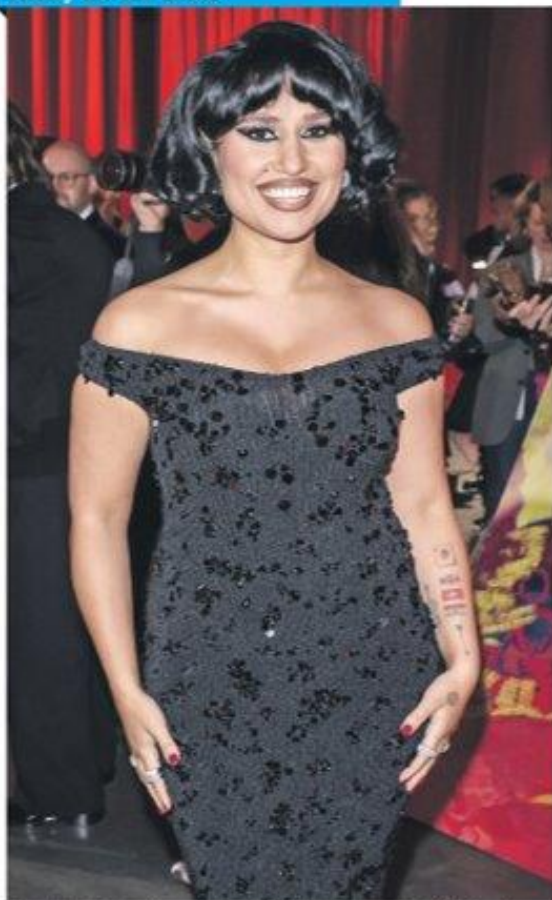
Warning against using the budget for political reasons and to satisfy demands from Tory MPs to slash spending and cut tax, they added: "Instead of sabotaging prospects for the next government, the chancellor should announce a package of measures to drive UK innovation and competitiveness, spur productivity and unlock new, intelligent and sustainable forms of growth."

Last night there were signs of tension between No 10 and the Treasury over tax and spend decisions, with Rishi Sunak said to be pushing harder for tax reductions.

Government sources said a move to reduce a planned rise in public spending for 2025 from 0.9% of GDP to 0.75% (which would raise £5bn)

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Ready for the Brits



Singer Raye, pictured before last night's Brits ceremony at the O2 in London, where she was nominated in seven categories – a record for one artist in one year. (Full story, page 11) JMEInternational/Getty

Fears over asthma drug side effects for children

Jon Ungood-Thomas

Children as young as three have suffered traumatic side effects from a blockbuster asthma drug now under review by the UK drugs regulator.

Families say asthma patients, including many children, are not properly warned of the risks from the commonly prescribed drug montelukast.

It has been associated with night terrors, depression and in rare cases hallucinations or suicidal behaviour.

The Medicines and Healthcare products Regulatory Agency (MHRA) confirmed this weekend it was reviewing the drug's risks after identifying "further concerns".

Tanya Hinder, from the montelukast UK action group, said: "Those affected have reported uncontrollable aggression, children attacking family members and suffering very intrusive thoughts. Tragically, there have also been attempted and reported suicides."

The UK action group for the drug, which represents nearly 3,500 members, is campaigning for more prominent warnings, stricter controls and support for those affected. It says patients should first consult a doctor if they have any concerns.

Graham and Alison Miller, whose son Harry, an asthma sufferer, took his life aged 14 in February 2018 while on the drug, are among the families calling for action. They learned of

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